through the day and the night. However, towards last light on 23 October, there were no men left as all of them had been killed or wounded. Surjit Singh was thought to be among the dead, but he was badly wounded and captured by the Chinese. Only four out of the thirty men managed to escape from Kongma.

By then, Raina knew the fate of Kongma, yet he agreed to back the younger man's instincts, for after all, Major Ajit Singh was the man on the ground.

After eliminating the Kongma positions, the Chinese spent the morning of 24 October harassing Tsogstsalu, after which they withdrew. However, news of fresh Chinese activity in the vicinity of Marsmik-la now prompted Raina to order Ajit Singh to withdraw from Hot Springs. Unable to ignore a direct order, Ajit Singh left a section to hold Hot Springs, after having sent a section earlier to Nullah Junction to reinforce the position there. Then with a column of eighty men, he started for Marsmik-la and reached Tsogstsalu at noon the next day. The fact that the Chinese were free to intercept the route to Phobrang prompted him to retrace his steps and head back down the Changchenmo Valley where he hoped to also link up with the other survivors of his battalion and 14 J&K Militia.

Once the party entered the narrow gorge of the Changchenmo, the bitter cold and freezing conditions got further amplified owing to having to sometimes wade through the river and its tributaries. Though IAF helicopters were regularly searching the area, because of the narrowness of the gorge, the party could not be spotted. Despite almost all men suffering from frostbite by then, Ajit Singh managed to keep his party alive and together, finally emerging at the track junction from where a goat track proceeded to Phobrang.

At this stage, the column was divided into two. Ajit Singh ordered Subedar Umaid Singh to take forty men and head for Phobrang while he would proceed to the Changchenmo-Shyok junction in the hope of finding stragglers from DBO and Galwan. The Phobrang column would take three days to reach its destination. Without exception, every man was suffering from the extreme cold and severe frostbite.

Ajit Singh's party in the meantime had reached the Shyok junction where they found another forty men who had escaped from the Chinese. Many had frozen to death and it was obvious to Ajit Singh that none of the rest could proceed any further unless resupplied from the air. Taking two